

World Health Organization (WHO) – Press Release

WHO Declares Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC) for Virus SPOK-24 Outbreak

Date: November 12, 2024 | **Location:** Geneva, Switzerland

WHO Declares Virus SPOK-24 a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC)

Following an emergency committee meeting, the World Health Organization (WHO) has declared the ongoing Virus SPOK-24 outbreak a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC) under the International Health Regulations (IHR 2005). This decision comes in response to the rapid increase in cases, sustained human-to-human transmission, and expanding international spread of the novel respiratory pathogen.

“Declaring a Public Health Emergency of International Concern is not a decision we take lightly,” said the WHO Director-General. “This designation underscores the urgency of global cooperation in controlling the spread of Virus SPOK-24 and ensuring a coordinated international response to mitigate its impact.”

CURRENT SITUATION

287 confirmed infections in Brisbane, Australia, with an estimated much higher number of undetected cases due to testing shortages.

408 total hospitalizations across multiple Australian cities, with new admissions reported in Sydney, Melbourne, Perth, Townsville, Mackay, and Hobart.

24 confirmed deaths, including fatalities in Brisbane, Sydney, Melbourne, Cairns, and Sunshine Coast.

Confirmed international spread to 20 countries across four continents, including the USA, China, New Zealand, Japan, Thailand, Spain, and Ireland.

Contact tracing efforts in Brisbane have been overwhelmed, making containment increasingly difficult.

WHO RECOMMENDATIONS TO COUNTRIES

- *Enhance Surveillance:* Implement screening for severe respiratory infections and test all cases with unexplained pneumonia for Virus SPOK-24.
- *Strengthen Healthcare Preparedness:* Ensure hospitals are equipped to manage severe respiratory illness and scale up intensive care unit (ICU) capacity.
- *Expand Laboratory Testing Capacity:* Provide Virus SPOK-24 testing capabilities to all major medical centers.

- **Travel & Border Measures:** WHO supports enhanced screening of travelers from affected areas but does not recommend blanket travel bans.
- **Public Health Communication:** Governments should provide transparent updates and promote respiratory precautions, mask use, and flu vaccination to prevent co-infections .

GLOBAL RESPONSE ACTIONS

- **International Travel Restrictions:** As of November 11 , multiple countries—including the USA, Russia, France, Spain, Italy, Ireland, Argentina, China, Switzerland, Belgium, Portugal, New Zealand, Taiwan, and Mexico —have restricted travel to and from Australia for humanitarian reasons only.
- **Scientific Response:** WHO is coordinating an international research initiative to accelerate diagnostic, therapeutic, and vaccine development for Virus SPOK-24.
- **Multinational Collaboration:** WHO is activating its Emergency Response Network (GOARN) to deploy experts and resources to affected regions.

STATEMENT FROM WHO DIRECTOR-GENERAL

“We recognize the significant disruption this outbreak is causing, both in Australia and globally,” said the WHO Director-General. “However, now is not the time for panic—it is the time for decisive, evidence-based action. We urge countries to implement our recommendations swiftly to slow the spread of Virus SPOK-24, protect healthcare systems, and safeguard lives.”

WHO will continue to provide real-time updates as more information becomes available. An Emergency Operations Center (EOC) has been activated , and additional Situation Reports will be released weekly.

For official updates, visit the WHO website at [www.who.int] or contact the WHO IHR Emergency Team at [email contact] .